

Use the same header from your resume to make the documents look like a set. Don't include this block if you use your resume header with contact info.

Your Name
Your Address
City, State Zip Code
Telephone Number
Email

Keep your letter short (one page) and professional.

The purpose of the cover letter is to connect the dots for the employer of why the skills on your resume prove you can do this particular job.

You can choose to not include the employer's mailing address if your cover letter is being submitted electronically.

Save your cover letter (and resume) as .pdf to avoid unwanted shifts in formatting.

Titles (e.g., Dr., Mr., Ms.) increase formality, but gendered titles should be avoided unless you are certain of their pronouns. It is better to leave a title off than to guess wrong.

Current Date (written out)

Employer's Name (ex: Mr. Charlie Smith)
Employer's Title (ex: University Recruiter)
Company Name
Company Address
City, State Zip Code

For emailed applications you can attach the cover letter .pdf with a short message or copy/paste the text in the body of the email. If the latter, start here.

Dear (Employer's Title, First, and Last Name):

If you absolutely cannot find a person to address the letter to, "Dear Hiring Manager" is standard.

Your first sentence should state which position you are applying for and how you found out about the possible job or internship. Use the exact title and include the posting number in parenthesis if applicable. Generally use a formal writing style - avoid slang and contractions (e.g., I'm, I'll, can't) in your cover letter - but adjust your tone to match the organization's work environment. Explain why you are interested in this particular role and organization; one brief sentence showing your enthusiasm for their mission goes a long way to help them picture you as a part of their team. In the remainder of the paragraph, you should make a strong opening statement about your personal brand and summarize your experiences (including your education/major) and skills that relate to the position. Make sure to frame your qualifications in terms of how they will benefit the organization if you receive the job. Just like a standard essay, your final sentence in your opening paragraph should be a "thesis statement" that summarizes your main qualifications (i.e., the specific skills that align with your analysis of the responsibilities outlined in the job description) in the order you will address them in the body of the letter.

In the second (and third or fourth, if needed) paragraph give specific examples of how you developed and previously demonstrated the relevant-to-this-job skills that you listed in your thesis. Coursework, paid jobs, clubs/activities, leadership roles, and volunteering are all valid experiences from which to pull examples. For example, if you are highlighting your communication skills, you could show your strong written and verbal communication skills through 1) the 15-page essay/report you wrote in XXX class, 2) the weekly updates you give in floor or chapter meetings for your residence hall floor or fraternity/sorority, and 3) your friendly, customer-focused communication style from your summer job at a restaurant. In addition to specific examples, you can also include relevant information about your approach, philosophy, or passion for that skill/task. Attempt to address each of the required or preferred skills from the job description in your cover letter's body paragraphs. Explicitly connect the dots to make the case for why your past experiences prove you can do the specific tasks and requirements of this job.

Use the final paragraph to refer the reader to your resume. Encourage the reader to follow up with any questions about your qualifications. Express hope/interest in continuing the conversation in an interview. Or let them know that you will follow up in one to two weeks. End the letter by thanking the person for their time and consideration.

Do not forget to follow up if you tell the employer you are going to do so.

Sincerely,

Your Signature
Your Name (first and last)

Inserting a scan of your signature is an optional touch that sets you apart and shows attention to detail.